Learning about students and their support preferences

Practical guide for subject lecturers | D16-S1

Use a brief survey to understand what students bring to the course and identify useful teaching adjustments. Combine their responses with classroom evidence and later conversations. A survey provides an initial picture rather than a diagnosis of language ability or support needs.

Prepare a short survey

Choose four to six questions that you can act on. Ask about relevant experiences, strengths and barriers. Avoid collecting personal details that you do not need. Explain who will see responses and follow institutional arrangements for handling them.

Introduce it clearly

“These questions help me plan examples, preparation and support for this course. They are not graded. You may skip any question, and you do not need to disclose personal circumstances. You can also speak with me privately.”

How to use the responses

- Look for patterns in experience with course tasks, subject concepts and digital tools. Do not infer ability from a student’s home language, ethnicity or previous institution.
- Choose a small adjustment you can explain: demonstrate an unfamiliar task, introduce key terms or provide a preparation example.
- Tell the class what you learned in general terms and what you will adjust. Do not identify individual responses.
- Offer private follow up where requested. Ask what would help rather than assuming a reported difficulty has one cause.
- Revisit after an early task. Compare survey responses with students’ work and invite corrections to your initial understanding.

Subject example

In a public health course, several students report little experience reading research articles. Model finding the question, method and findings in one article. Later check whether students can use these headings independently.

Adaptable learning experience survey

Opening statement: Your responses help me plan this course. This is not assessed. Skip any question you prefer not to answer. Contact me through [course contact route] if you would prefer a private conversation.

1. What relevant subject topics or practical experiences have you studied or encountered before?
   Response: _____
2. Which course tasks have you done before, such as analysing a case, discussing evidence or writing a report? Which are new?
   Response: _____
3. What is one strength or experience you bring to this course?
   Response: _____
4. What helps you work through a difficult explanation or unfamiliar task?
   Response: _____
5. If you wish to share, which languages do you use when studying, making notes or discussing ideas?
   Response: _____
6. Is there anything about accessing materials or participating in course activities that you would like me to consider?
   Response: _____

A later check in

After two or three weeks, ask “What has helped you learn so far?” and “What remains difficult?” Offer an optional private response route. Treat preferences as useful information, not fixed learning styles.

Supporting sources

Briggs, N. B. (n.d.). *First day of class*. University of Illinois Chicago, Center for the Advancement of Teaching Excellence.